

SEctOr Design System

The brief, stated plainly

SEctOr is not a startup growth tool. It's a trust instrument for Indian NGOs — small, often under-resourced organizations handing over FCRA numbers, PAN details, and WordPress admin credentials to a product they've likely never heard of. The design's one job is to make that handover feel safe, competent, and respectful of their time. Every aesthetic choice below is in service of that, not of looking impressive in a portfolio.

The product's single most characteristic moment — the thing that should anchor the whole visual identity — is a number appearing. A visitor pastes a URL; seconds later, a score (0-100) and a plain-language breakdown of why appear. That moment, not a hero illustration or a gradient, is the hero.

Reject, deliberately: the warm-cream-and-terracotta AI-generated look, glossy SaaS gradients, "move fast" energy, urgency countdown timers, stock photos of diverse people smiling at laptops, dark-mode-with-neon-accent hacker aesthetics, and anything that reads as *selling* rather than *explaining*. An NGO program officer evaluating this at 11pm after a full day of actual program work should feel like a careful, precise colleague built it — not a growth team.

1. Color

A **paper-and-ink** base with exactly one living color, used sparingly enough that it still means something when it appears.

Token	Hex	Role
<code>paper</code>	<code>#F6F7F3</code>	Page background. A whisper of sage, not cream — cool enough to avoid the generic warm-latte AI look, warm enough not to feel clinical-cold.
<code>ink</code>	<code>#161B17</code>	Primary text, headlines, the score numeral. Near-black with a trace of green in it — ties to the accent without announcing it.
<code>ink-muted</code>	<code>#5B6058</code>	Secondary text, captions, timestamps, helper copy.
<code>line</code>	<code>#E2E4DC</code>	Hairline borders, dividers, input outlines. Low-contrast on purpose — structure should be felt, not shouted.
<code>pine</code>	<code>#1F4D3B</code>	The one accent. Primary actions, links, a passing check, the score ring when the score is good. Deep, desaturated, botanical — reads as growth and groundedness without being a cliché "NGO green" (no Kelly green, no gradient).
<code>ochre</code>	<code>#9C6B1F</code>	"This needs attention" — used on failed checks and warnings. Deliberately <i>not</i> red. Nothing in this product is an emergency; a failing check is guidance, not an alarm. Reserve true red (<code>#B3261E</code>), used nowhere in v1) for actual destructive/error states only — a failed payment, a confirmed delete — so it stays meaningful when it does appear.

Dark mode (secondary, not the design center of gravity): invert to `ink` (`#161B17`) as background, `paper` as primary text, `pine` lightened to `#4A8A6F` for sufficient contrast, `ochre` lightened to `#C99445`. Don't design *for* dark mode first — this is a daytime, during-work-hours product.

Rule: `pine` is spent on exactly two things — primary buttons/links, and "this passed." If a third use case needs a color, it gets `ink` or `ink-muted`, never a second accent. This is the single most important restraint in this system.

2. Type

Display / the score itself: Newsreader — an editorial serif with real optical-size range, built for long-form reading at large sizes. Used for the score numeral, page headlines, and nowhere else. It gives the product a register above generic SaaS without reaching for the overused high-contrast-display-serif-on-cream combination.

UI / body / everything else: Public Sans — the typeface the U.S. government's own design system was built on. It exists specifically to be legible, neutral, and trustworthy at small sizes across a civic product used by people who didn't choose to be designers' audience. That's a closer match to "NGO back-office staff filling in a form" than any startup-coded grotesk. Use it for body text, labels, buttons, inputs, everything that isn't the score or a headline.

Two families, clearly distinct roles — not decoration, division of labor: Newsreader *announces*, Public Sans *explains*.

Type scale (base 16px, ratio 1.25 — modest, not a dramatic editorial jump, because most of this product is a working tool, not a magazine):

Role	Size / line-height	Family / weight
Score numeral	72px / 1.0	Newsreader, weight 400 (not bold — let size carry it)
Page headline	32px / 1.2	Newsreader, weight 500
Section heading	20px / 1.3	Public Sans, weight 600
Body	16px / 1.6	Public Sans, weight 400
Small / caption	13px / 1.5	Public Sans, weight 400, <code>ink-muted</code>

Line length: cap body text at ~70 characters. No ALL-CAPS labels anywhere — use sentence case and `ink-muted` color to de-emphasize, not uppercase tracking (the single most common tell of a templated page).

3. Layout

Alignment: left-aligned throughout. No centered hero card, no symmetric marketing-site layout. Left alignment reads as a working tool you sit down and use, not a landing page you're sold on — consistent with the "colleague, not vendor" voice.

The audit result — the core screen:

hopefoundation.org	
audited 2 minutes ago	
68	← Newsreader 72px,
—	ink, left-aligned,
out of 100	NOT centered,
	NOT in a card
✓ Structured data present	
Organization schema found in page head	
× AI crawlers blocked	← ochre mark,
robots.txt disallows GPTBot, ClaudeBot	not red
[Fix this]	
✓ Heading hierarchy	
...	

No card chrome around the score — it sits directly on the paper background. Findings are a plain list with generous vertical rhythm (24px between items), not a grid of identical bordered cards (the "SaaS-card-kit" default this system explicitly avoids). Each failing finding carries its own inline fix action — not a separate "remediation dashboard" the person has to go find.

Dashboard / logged-in shell:

SEctOr Hope Foundation Alice · owner

Audits Ad Grants Content

[left column, ~65% width: primary content, left-aligned]

[right column, ~35%: contextual — latest score trend,
open compliance alerts, nothing decorative]

A thin single hairline under the nav, nothing else. No sidebar icon rail, no collapsed-by-default navigation — NGO staff are not power users clicking through a dense admin panel forty times a day; wayfinding should need zero learning curve.

Spacing scale: 4 / 8 / 12 / 16 / 24 / 32 / 48 / 64px. Every margin and padding value in the product comes from this list — no arbitrary 13px or 22px anywhere.

Radius: one value, 6px, on inputs, buttons, and the rare contained surface (a modal, a toast). Not 0 (too severe/broadsheet), not 16px+ (too bubbly/consumer-app). 6px reads as precise without being cold.

Shadow: none, by default. If a floating element genuinely needs separation (a dropdown, a modal), a single hairline border does the job before a shadow does. The product has zero drop-shadow-under-every-card styling — that's a tell, and it's also just noise.

4. Motion

One deliberate moment: when an audit completes, the score counts up from 0 to its final value over ~600ms (ease-out), and the ring/underline beneath it draws in sync. That's it. That's the one orchestrated animation in the product — it's earned, because it's the literal payoff moment the whole funnel exists to deliver.

Everything else: instant or near-instant (150ms) opacity/color transitions on hover and focus, nothing more. No fade-and-slide-up on scroll, no staggered card entrances, no hover-lift-and-shadow on every button. `(prefers-reduced-motion)` disables even

the count-up — it becomes an instant reveal of the final number.

5. Voice (this is a design material, not a copy afterthought)

- Buttons say exactly what happens: "Run free audit", "Apply fix to my WordPress site", "Record consent" — never "Submit" or "Go."
 - The name of an action stays identical through the whole flow. The button that says "Run audit" leads to a result, never a toast that says something else.
 - Errors state what happened and what to do, in plain language, without apologizing or hedging: *"Could not crawl that URL. It may be unreachable, blocking automated requests, or took too long to respond."* Not "Oops!" Not "Something went wrong, please try again later, we apologize for the inconvenience."
 - Never oversell. "This needs attention" instead of "Critical issue detected!!" An NGO reading a dozen findings should feel equipped, not alarmed.
 - No em-dash-joined meta strings, no middle-dot-separated label chains, no "WORD — fragment" constructions. Write sentences.
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6. Quality floor (non-negotiable, not a stretch goal)

- WCAG AA contrast minimum everywhere — `ink` on `paper` is ~14:1; `ink-muted` on `paper` is checked to stay above 4.5:1 at the sizes it's used at.
 - Visible keyboard focus ring on every interactive element — 2px `pine` outline, never `outline: none` without a replacement.
 - Fully responsive down to a 360px viewport — most NGO staff in this audience will open an audit link on a phone first.
 - `prefers-reduced-motion` respected everywhere, not just the score count-up.
 - Never color alone for pass/fail — the ✓/✗ mark and the word ("passed" / "needs attention") always carry the meaning; color reinforces it.
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Why this, and not the obvious alternative

The obvious pitch for an "AI discoverability" product is to look futuristic — dark background, neon accent, glowing gradient, the visual language of "we are an AI company." That's wrong for this specific audience: NGO staff aren't being sold on AI, they're being asked to trust a stranger with their organization's credentials. Paper, ink, one quiet green, an editorial serif reserved for the one number that matters — that reads as a careful institution, which is the actual sales pitch here, said through design rather than copy.